MARKETING MANAGEMENT · SESSION DECK

POSITIONING

Brand Positioning & Repositioning — Concepts, Frameworks and Real Cases

Owning a place in the customer's mind, one decision at a time.

Prepared for: [Course / Session Name] Date: [DD Month YYYY]

WARM-UP ACTIVITY · 10 MINUTES

Ice-Breaker: Guess the Brand

How it works

- Form pairs or small groups.
- Each clue card describes a famous brand — using only its tagline, colour, category and one attribute. No logo, no name.
- You get 60 seconds per card to write down your guess.
- Score 1 point per correct brand. Highest score shares their score first!
- No searching online — trust your gut and your memory.

Why do this?

Because in a few seconds, your brain will identify a brand from almost nothing. That instant recall is what today's session is all about.

ICE-BREAKER · CLUE CARDS

Five Brands, Five Clues — Who Are They?

1

Category: Sportswear

Tagline: “Just Do It”

Colours: Black & White · Symbol: A single swoosh

Brand: _____

2

Category: Coffeehouse

Positioning: “The Third Place”

Colours: Deep Green & White · Founded in Seattle, 1971

Brand: _____

3

Category: Automobile

Owned word: “Safety”

Origin: Sweden · Manufacturing cars since 1927

Brand: _____

4

Category: Technology

Tagline: “Think Different”

Symbol: A bitten fruit · Products named after letters (i-)

Brand: _____

5

Category: Soft Drink

Tagline: “Open Happiness”

Colours: Red & White · Signature contour glass bottle

Brand: _____

What Just Happened?

Answers: 1) Nike 2) Starbucks 3) Volvo 4) Apple 5) Coca-Cola

- You identified each brand from a colour, a tagline and one word — not a logo, not a product photo.
- That is positioning at work: a brand claiming one clear, differentiated space inside your mind.
- Every brand you named has spent decades defending that one space against competitors.
- Today's session is about how that space is built (positioning) and how it is rebuilt when it stops working (repositioning).

ROADMAP

What We'll Cover Today

1. **Positioning Fundamentals**

   Definition, why it matters, and how it differs from a product feature

2. **Bases & the Positioning Statement**

   Seven ways to position + a reusable statement template

3. **Brand Positioning in Action**

   Perceptual mapping and three real-world cases

4. **Repositioning**

   Triggers, approaches, and three turnaround cases

5. **Comparison & Takeaways**

   Positioning vs. repositioning, key lessons, group activity

What Is Positioning?

> *“Positioning is not what you do to a product. It is what you do to the mind of the prospect.”*
>
> — Al Ries & Jack Trout, “Positioning: The Battle for Your Mind”

- Positioning is about perception, not the physical product itself.
- It exists relative to competitors — always in comparison, never in isolation.
- It happens inside the customer's mind, built through every touchpoint.
- It is a deliberate strategic choice, not an accident of advertising.

Why Positioning Matters

5,000+

Brand messages an average person is exposed to every single day

Seconds

Is roughly all it takes for a consumer to form a first brand impression

Top-of-Mind

Recall drives the default choice when a buyer isn't actively comparing

Premium

Clear, credible positioning is what lets a brand charge more than generic rivals

Bottom line: without a clear position, a brand becomes a commodity competing on price alone.

Seven Bases for Positioning a Brand

1 Attribute

A specific product feature

Volvo → crash-safety engineering

2 Benefit

The problem it solves

Sensodyne → relief from tooth sensitivity

3 Use / Occasion

When or how it's used

Gatorade → post-workout rehydration

4 User

Who it's designed for

Johnson's → gentle, baby-safe care

5 Competitor

Defined against a rival

Avis → "We try harder" (vs. Hertz)

6 Category

Creating / leading a category

Red Bull → defined the energy-drink category

7 Quality / Price

A clear value tier

Zara → fast fashion at accessible prices

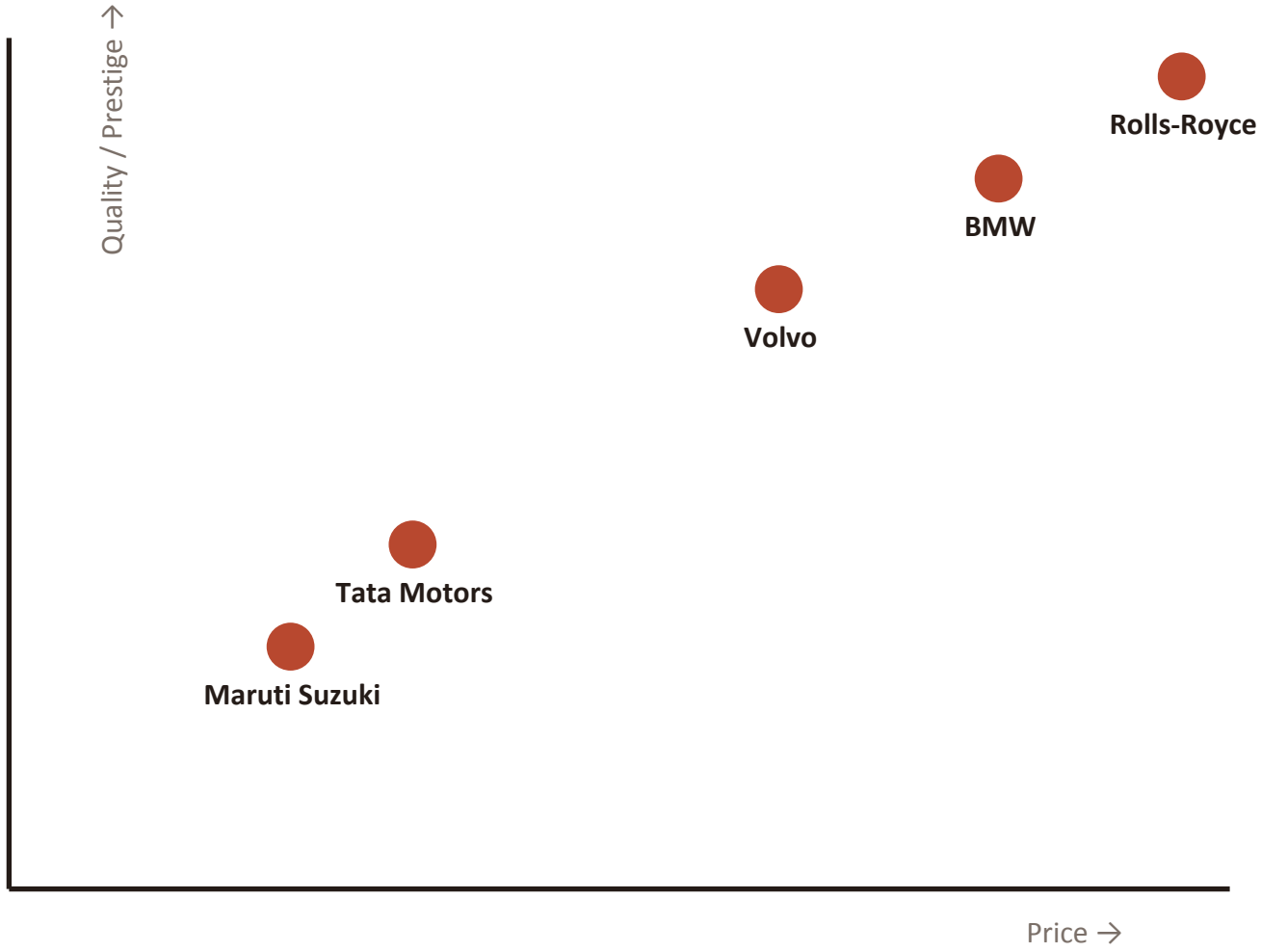
The Positioning Statement Template

For **[target segment]** who **[need / opportunity]**, **[Brand]** is a **[category]** that **[key benefit]**, unlike **[main competitor]**, because **[reason to believe].**

Worked Example — Volvo

For safety-conscious families who need a dependable everyday car, Volvo is a premium automobile brand that delivers the industry's most advanced safety engineering — unlike other luxury brands — because of over 90 years of dedicated safety research (including inventing and freely sharing the 3-point seatbelt).

Perceptual Mapping: Seeing the White Space



Why map it?

- Plot competitors on the two attributes that matter most to buyers.
- Clusters reveal over-crowded positions to avoid.
- Empty quadrants (“white space”) reveal opportunities for a new brand or a repositioning move.
- This same map is used later to decide where a brand should reposition to.

SECTION 3 · SMALL CASE 1

Volvo — Owning “Safety”

“Safety has been and always will be at the core of what we do.”

Background

Swedish automaker, founded 1927. Entered a category dominated by speed and styling claims from German and American rivals.

The Positioning Move

Chose one attribute — safety — and refused to dilute it. Invented the 3-point seatbelt in 1959 and gave the patent away free, for the public good.

Result & Takeaway

Decades later, “Volvo” and “safety” are near-synonyms worldwide. Lesson: attribute positioning works only with decades of consistent, credible investment.

SECTION 3 · SMALL CASE 2

Apple — “Think Different”

Positioning through design, simplicity and identity — not just specifications.

Background

1997: Apple was months from bankruptcy, seen as a niche computer maker losing badly to Windows PCs on price and market share.

The Positioning Move

Repositioned around creativity and simplicity for “the crazy ones” — designers, students, rebels — rather than specs or price.

Result & Takeaway

Became one of the world's most valuable brands with strong pricing power. Lesson: positioning can be emotional/aspirational, not only functional.

SECTION 3 · SMALL CASE 3

FedEx — A Single Benefit Claim

“When it absolutely, positively has to be there overnight.” (1978)

Background

Express air-cargo delivery was new and unreliable in the 1970s; customers had no confidence in guaranteed delivery times.

The Positioning Move

Claimed one crystal-clear benefit — guaranteed overnight delivery — and organised the entire operating model around delivering on it.

Result & Takeaway

“FedEx it” entered everyday language as a verb. Lesson: a single, well-proven benefit claim can become category shorthand.

What Is Repositioning?

Deliberately changing how customers perceive a brand relative to competitors — with or without changing the physical product.

Common Triggers

- Sales decline or shrinking relevance
- Shifting consumer values or lifestyles
- New, better-positioned competitors entering
- Brand image out of sync with the actual product
- A deliberate move into a new customer segment
- Product improvements the market hasn't noticed yet

Four Approaches to Repositioning

1

Image

Same product, new perception

Change tone, channels and creative — no product change (e.g., a heritage brand adopting a youthful voice).

2

Product

Same audience, improved product

Reformulate or rebuild the product itself to match the promise being made.

3

Intangible

Same product, new audience

Keep the product as-is; shift targeting and messaging to a different segment.

4

Tangible

New product, new audience

Change both the offering and the target — the highest-risk, highest-reward move.

SECTION 4 · REPOSITIONING CASE 1

Old Spice — "The Man Your Man Could Smell Like"

Image repositioning: same core product, a completely new voice.

The Problem

By the late 2000s, Old Spice was seen as an old-fashioned brand mothers bought for fathers and grandfathers — losing young men to Axe/Lynx.

The Reposition (2010)

Launched a comedic, viral, social-media-first campaign — witty, self-aware, aimed at young men and the women who buy for them.

Result & Takeaway

Sales reportedly grew sharply in the months after launch; the brand became culturally relevant again. Lesson: tone and channel alone can revive a heritage brand.

SECTION 4 · REPOSITIONING CASE 2

Domino's Pizza — “The Pizza Turnaround”

Product + tangible repositioning, built on radical honesty.

The Problem

By 2009, Domino's pizza was widely mocked for bland, “cardboard-like” crust and ketchup-tasting sauce — sales and image were both suffering.

The Reposition

Publicly aired real customer complaints in national ads, admitted the criticism, and reformulated the entire recipe from scratch.

Result & Takeaway

The company's stock and sales climbed strongly over the following years. Lesson: repositioning a product claim requires the product to actually change first.

SECTION 4 · REPOSITIONING CASE 3 (INDIA)

Cadbury Dairy Milk — “Kuch Khaas Hai”

Intangible repositioning: same chocolate, a completely new user base.

The Problem

Since its 1948 India launch, Dairy Milk was seen mainly as a children's treat — adults rarely bought it for themselves, capping growth.

The Reposition (1990s)

The iconic “cricket ground dance” ad reframed chocolate as a way to celebrate any special moment in life — for people of every age.

Result & Takeaway

Dairy Milk became India's largest chocolate brand, now bought across all age groups. Lesson: repositioning the user base can unlock an entirely new market.

Positioning vs. Repositioning

Aspect	Positioning	Repositioning
When it's used	New brand or product entering a market	Existing brand facing decline, or a market shift
Primary goal	Establish a clear, distinct place in the mind	Change or refresh an existing perception
Starting point	A blank slate — no prior perception to fight	Must first overcome an existing (often outdated) perception
Risk level	Lower — one clean narrative to build	Higher — old associations can resurface or confuse buyers
Product change?	Not required to launch the position	May or may not be required, depending on the approach
Example from today	FedEx entering express delivery (1970s)	Old Spice reviving relevance with young buyers (2010)

Key Takeaways

1. Positioning lives in the customer's mind, not in the factory or the spec sheet.
2. Own one word or idea where possible — narrow focus beats a broad, blurry claim.
3. A positioning statement should guide every downstream marketing decision.
4. Repositioning is costly and risky — attempt it only with clear evidence it's needed.
5. Consistency sustained over years (even decades) is what builds true category ownership.

CLOSING ACTIVITY · 10 MINUTES

Your Turn: Draft a Repositioning Statement

In groups of 4:

1. Pick one under-performing or old-fashioned brand (real or fictional).
2. Identify why its current position is failing — use the triggers from Section 4.
3. Choose a repositioning approach: image, product, intangible or tangible.
4. Write a one-line positioning statement using today's template.
5. Be ready to pitch it to the room in under a minute.

THANK YOU

Questions & Discussion

[Presenter Name] · [Email / Contact]